

1901–1914

SUITS FOR CITY GENTLEMEN

The turn of the century did not herald major changes to the three-piece suit, although some styles were gradually replaced or began to be used for different occasions. For the day the black frock coat with its long, straight skirt, worn with black trousers, was the most formal option. It was followed by the morning coat (“cutaway frock” in America) with its sloping front, which could be worn with matching or contrasting trousers.

The lounge suit, originally country wear, was now worn in town. In the evening options gradually expanded as “tails” (tailcoats) were joined by tuxedos (tail-less dinner jackets), at first only considered appropriate for informal dinner parties. More formal attire demanded the stiff collar, available in several shapes. Men had a wide choice of accessories including canes, umbrellas, a variety of hat styles, cravats, bow ties, watch chains, and tiepins.

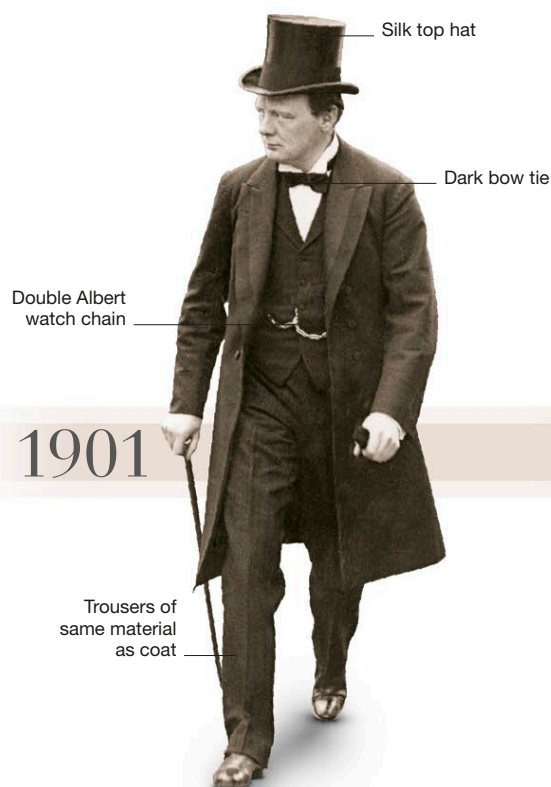
ROYAL FASHION LEADER



King Edward VII had become a male fashion icon when he was still Prince Albert of Wales, popularizing the Norfolk jacket, the Homburg hat, and the Albert watch chain. The king also lent his name to double-breasted frock coats, which he preferred. The unusual closure shown here might have had more to do with his increasing girth than with any fashionable considerations.

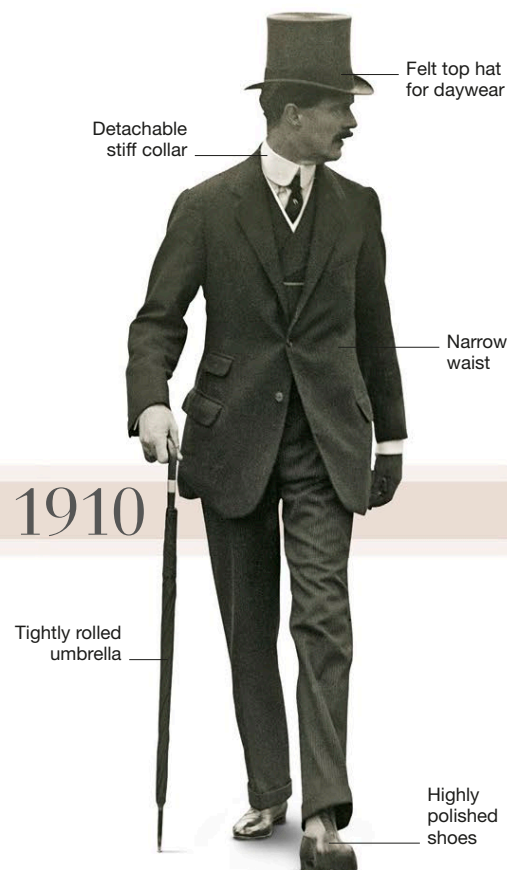


Morning coat The very dapper Lord Chesterfield wears his morning coat with white waistcoat, shirt with high stiff collar, striped cravat, and prominent buttonhole (the flower worn on the lapel).



1901

Frock coat A young Winston Churchill wears a single-breasted black frock coat with customary silk-faced lapels. His top hat and cane indicate this is a formal outing – they were beginning to be associated only with special occasions.



1910

Lounge suit Unusually the Duke of Roxburghe wears a lounge suit, rather than morning coat, to call at Buckingham Palace. A waistcoat slip, a stiff cotton strip attached to the neckline of his waistcoat, gives the illusion of a second waistcoat worn beneath.